

Cabinet**17:37 to 19:36****Wednesday, 11 March 2026**

Present: Councillors Stonard (Leader), Hampton (Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment), Harper (Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects), Jones (Cabinet Member for Housing), Kidman (Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing) and Padda (Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice).

Apologies: None

In attendance Councillor Galvin (Leader of the Green Group)

116. Declarations of interest

116.1 There were no declarations of interest.

117. Public questions and petitions

117.1 There had been three public questions and one petition submitted to the meeting.

117.2 Anna Wright asked the following question to Councillor Harper, Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects:

" Regarding the proposed Norwich Market bike park revamp, I wish to challenge the project's transparency and procedural validity.

Engagement: Why were standard on-site laminated flyers bypassed, resulting in a survey recording only 56 opposing voices, while my petition currently has 1,133 signatures (and counting) against the plan?

Heritage: Under the Planning Act 1990, has a formal Heritage Impact Assessment been conducted for this 90-year-old hub?

Prematurity: Why were trial pits dug on 21 February for the covered seating area, suggesting the council has entered the 'formal design stage' months before the Autumn 2026 planning decision?

Given these discrepancies in public engagement and the physical works already underway, will the Cabinet commit to publishing a full, independent

impact assessment before any further work begins, and explain why the project appears to be progressing before planning consent is granted?"

- 117.3 Councillor Harper, Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

"Thank you for your questions regarding the Norwich Market project.

Firstly, the Council has not developed any proposals for changes to the motorcycle parking area or the wider public realm. There appears to be a misconception that the proposed covered seating area is located on the motorcycle park. I can confirm it is not. The seating area is proposed within the Market itself.

Over the past 12 months, we have carried out two public consultations inviting comments on design ideas and potential operational changes for the Market. Respondents were also able to comment on the surrounding public realm, including Gentlemans Walk and the motorcycle parking area. These consultations were exploratory and designed to gather information. They were widely promoted through on-site QR codes, the Council's website, social media, and local media coverage. Across both consultations, we received over 3,800 responses.

A Heritage Impact Assessment is not required at this stage. Should any proposals be developed, all statutory processes, including heritage assessments and planning notices, would follow as part of any future planning application.

The trial pits you refer to were not undertaken by Norwich City Council and are unrelated to the Market project. They are part of Norfolk County Council's highways works in the area.

Given that no scheme is being progressed for the motorcycle park, there is no basis for commissioning an independent impact assessment at this time.

However, this administration remains committed to investing in and improving the Market and supporting its position as the best medieval market in Europe. We will continue to develop our exciting plans for the market and look forward to being able to take these to the next stage of their progression."

- 117.4 By way of a supplementary question Anna Wright asked that the Cabinet Member guarantee that no changes would be made to the motorcycle park. In response the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects reiterated that the consultation had been on wider changes to Norwich Market and not the motorcycle park. With Local Government Reorganisation on the horizon Norwich City Council would cease to exist and could not bind the new authority in such a way.

- 117.5 The second question was from Amber Smith, Amber Smith asked Councillor Kidman, the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing the following question:

“Pride in Place is described as a programme intended to place local communities at the heart of decisions on significant government investment. I live in Bowthorpe, where some of this funding is targeted.

I understand that the interview panel for appointing the independent neighbourhood board chairs will be chaired by the local MP, alongside a Cabinet Member and a council officer.

Given that these appointments relate to the governance of substantial public funding facilitated by the council, how does this selection process ensure visible political balance and demonstrable independence so that residents can have confidence that appointments are impartial and not influenced by party-political considerations?”

117.6 Councillor Kidman, the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing gave the following response:

“Pride in Place presents a significant opportunity for two of our most deprived communities. Over the next ten years the area of Bowthorpe and West Earlham and the area of Heartsease and Pilling Park will each get £20 million of funding to create thriving places with stronger communities where residents are in control of their own lives.

Once in place, the Neighbourhood Boards are responsible for decisions on how to spend the funding and they will have to evidence through extensive community engagement that their spending decisions reflect the priorities of the local community. The Council will initially be the accountable body and hold responsibility for ensuring that the guidance is adhered to and all legal and compliance requirements are met.

Each Neighbourhood Board will be led by an independent Chair. In line with the guidance from the government, this individual will be appointed and approved by the local authority and the MP. They will be a champion for the place and have a strong connection to the neighbourhood. The guidance outlines they cannot be an elected member such as a local councillor.

For each position, we have conducted an open recruitment process with press releases, social media posts and the sharing of information through community networks to ensure we reach the right people. The selection panel is chaired by the local MP alongside myself as Cabinet Member responsible for Pride in Place and a council officer. In Bowthorpe and West Earlham, an independent community leader will also be joining the interview panel to give an additional local perspective.

As with all good recruitment processes, we have adopted an evidence-based approach to the selection process with the criteria that we score against being taken from the Pride in Place programme prospectus. Candidates are scored against how they meet the key criteria of the role at shortlisting stage, with the successful ones being invited to an in-person interview with the selection panel. The interviews are made up of a consistent set of competency-based questions which the interview panel then score based on how well the

candidate has answered the question. These scores will determine who will be offered the role.

A due diligence process will be undertaken by the Council to make sure the successful candidate is independent and will be able to lead the Neighbourhood Board in line with the published guidance and free from party-political influence.”

117.7 As a supplementary question Amber Smith asked for assurances that following other similar schemes that had failed whether this scheme would be different and truly benefit residents in Bowthorpe and West Earlham, in response the Cabinet Member for Culture and Wellbeing confirmed that the scheme was different to previous schemes and would have robust governance with a Chair and Board and would be governed in a transparent and robust manner with no party political considerations.

117.8 Councillor Kidman left the meeting at this point.

117.9 The third question was from Georgia Brumby, Georgia Brumby asked Councillor Harper, the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects the following questions:

“Since demolition began at Anglia Square, businesses on Magdalen Street have reported significant reductions in footfall and turnover, with customers expressing confusion about parking and access.

What immediate and time-limited measures will the Council implement to improve clarity of access and support footfall during the demolition phase?”

117.10 Councillor Harper, the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

“Thank you for your question.

We completely understand the concerns that have been raised by businesses on Magdalen Street. Any major redevelopment will inevitably cause some degree of disruption. We also know there have been some reports about footfall in the area so we will continue to do everything we can to keep disruption to a minimum.

The recent closure of Magdalen Street was necessary for safety reasons while demolition work was underway. I am pleased to confirm here today that two days ago, Magdalen Street was fully re-opened which is great news for those who had concerns about its brief closure.

Throughout the closure we made sure pedestrian routes stayed open, we put up signage to reassure people that businesses were still trading and we organised for letters to be delivered to residents in the nearby area, in advance of the closure, to make them aware.

We know that parking has been another topic highlighted by some traders, so I'm happy to confirm that we've recently reopened St Crispins car park to provide extra capacity in that area of the city.

Alongside this, the St Saviours Yard meanwhile space has been successfully up and running for some time now. It immediately drew people into the area and has created another reason to visit that part of the city – and helping footfall during the demolition phase. We'll keep working closely with traders and partners and will share key updates on the project while this ambitious redevelopment progresses.”

117.11 In response to Georgia Brumby's supplementary question the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects said that the disruption was expected for a regeneration scheme of this size and the disruption was regrettable. The Council was working to mitigate where possible. Shopping habits had changed significantly however the development of a significant number of new homes in the area along with community and retail space would help to revive the area.

117.12 Anna Wright presented the following petition to Cabinet:

“Norwich City Council has initiated plans to change the longstanding motorbike park amid the ongoing market redevelopment. This move is based on a flawed survey and poses a significant threat to a facility that has served the community for several decades.

It has come to our attention that from a survey of 700 respondents, not one individual known to the regular users of the motorbike park was included. This raises concerns about the fairness and inclusivity of the process. A decision of such magnitude, affecting countless individuals who rely on this parking space, should not be made based on biased or incomplete data.

The Norwich motorbike park is not just a parking space; it is a vital part of the city infrastructure that supports local commuters, shop owners, and businesses. It facilitates convenient access for riders who contribute significantly to the local economy. Removing or altering this facility could lead to financial loss for businesses that benefit from the ease of access it provides to riders.

Furthermore, it is important to recognise the cultural and historical significance of the motorbike park. For decades, it has been a hub for riders, fostering a sense of community and shared identity among motorbike enthusiasts in Norwich.

We urge Norwich City Council to recognise the substantial impact this change will have on our community and to immediately halt any plans to alter the motorbike park. Instead, a more inclusive and transparent consultation process should be conducted, ensuring that all stakeholders, particularly the regular users of the facility, have their voices heard and considered in the decision-making process.

Sign this petition to protect the Norwich motorbike park and to advocate for a fair and inclusive approach in the city's redevelopment plans. Your support is crucial in preserving a beloved and essential part of our community."

117.13 Councillor Harper, the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

"Thank you to everyone who has taken the time to engage with the recent consultations relating to Norwich's provisions market.

Over the past 12 months, we have held two public consultations inviting feedback on design ideas and potential operational changes for the market. These consultations were widely advertised and received 3,503 responses, demonstrating strong public interest and engagement in the future of the market.

It is therefore unfortunate that a substantial amount of misleading information has circulated alongside this petition, particularly on social media. This has created unnecessary concern about matters that were not included in the council's proposals. Officers have proactively sought to clarify these issues with the lead petitioner and have offered a meeting to explain the scope of the consultation and the proposals relating to the provisions market. Regrettably, that offer has been declined.

To be absolutely clear:

- The consultation did not include any proposal to close the motorcycle park, nor did it involve any proposals regarding its removal or relocation.
- The consultation included one question about the motorcycle park as part of a much wider exercise intended to gather views on how the provisions market and its adjoining public space is used.

My focus, and the focus of the council, remains on ensuring that Norwich city centre and the provisions market continue to thrive and serve residents, businesses, and visitors. Our goal is to strengthen the market's position as the best medieval market in Europe."

118. Questions to cabinet members

118.1 The Leader announced that there had been five questions received from Members of the Council to be put to Cabinet Members for which notice had been given in accordance with the provisions of Part 3 of the Council's Constitution.

118.2 The questions are summarised as follows:

118.3 Councillor Champion to the Cabinet Member for Housing on the installation of anti-bird comb on Council properties.

118.4 Councillor Stutely to the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects on Anglia Square Management Plan.

- 118.5 Councillor Knight to the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment on the conditions of advertising at bus shelters.
- 118.6 Councillor Stutely to the Leader of the Council on measures within the draft Statement of Licensing Policy to prevent sexual harassment and spiking.
- 118.7 Councillor Stutely to the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects on the St Saviours Yard toilets.
- 118.8 Full details of the question and response were available on the Council's website prior to the meeting. A revised version is attached to these minutes at Appendix A and includes a minute of any supplementary questions and responses.

119. Minutes

- 119.1 **RESOLVED** to confirm the minutes of the meetings, including the exempt minutes, held on 14 January 2026 and 11 February 2026.

120. Notice of Intention to Commence Plan Making

- 120.1 The Leader of the Council presented the item. The Council was required to start commencement of the next version of the Greater Norwich Local Plan, to be known as the GNLP 2045 under the new plan-making system due to significant changes to national planning policy. There had also been a number of other factors that required an earlier review; the commitment to do so under the Local Development Scheme 2025; Greater Norwich's local housing need having risen significantly and there was a need to allocate sites for housing; the new plan would supersede the Council's Development Management Policies Plan; regulations and funding had been put in place to support plan-making and the opportunity to identify further areas for growth and development.
- 120.2 The Council was required to publish a notice to commence and a local plan timetable, this was scheduled for the Greater Norwich area for 30 June 2026. This would trigger the statutory 30-month Local Plan preparation cycle starting on 30 October 2026. The notice to commence would provide clarity to communities, stakeholders and statutory bodies on the engagement and consultation activities for GNLP 2045.
- 120.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:
- “Given the well-documented viability pressures that often favour greenfield development over brownfield regeneration, can the Cabinet Member explain how the new plan-making process for the Greater Norwich Local Plan 2045 will ensure that previously developed land is genuinely prioritised, and that the protection of the green belt and other environmentally sensitive land is not undermined by short-term pressures to meet these much increased housing delivery targets?”
- 120.4 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:
- “Current planning policy in Greater Norwich seeks to maximise the opportunities for brownfield development in our area, and the great majority of the housing allocations in the GNLP in Norwich itself are on brownfield sites. This includes the

two strategic regeneration sites at East Norwich and the North City Centre which are both currently being moved forward.

Additionally, 62% of the total housing growth in the GNLP to 2038 is in the Norwich urban area, which includes urban extensions such as the northeast growth triangle.

The viability of brownfield development is an important issue facing Norwich, Greater Norwich and the country. Changes to national policy which are currently being consulted on in the draft NPPF will strengthen the support for brownfield development. This will include an additional focus on urban and suburban densification and on growth near railway stations.

Part of the role of the GNLP 2045 will be to examine how best to apply this locally. This could include additional brownfield allocations and looking into ways of locally increasing the viability of and support for the development of brownfield sites.”

120.5 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

120.6 **RESOLVED** to recommend that Full Council:

- 1) Approves the commencement of the Greater Norwich Local Plan 2045 under the new plan-making system by publishing:
 - a) The Local Plan Timetable and Notice to Commence on 30 June 2026
 - b) The Gateway 1 self-assessment readiness check by 30 October 2026.
- 2) Delegates authority to the Head of Planning and Regulatory Services to make any future amendments to the Local Plan Timetable which may be required and to complete the Notice to Commence and the Gateway 1 self-assessment
- 3) Agrees the broad outline of the scoping consultation as set out in paragraphs 23-26 of the report and delegates authority to the Head of Planning and Regulatory Services to detail this and to begin the scoping

121. GNLP Policy 2: Sustainable Communities Draft Supplementary Planning Document (SPD)

121.1 The Leader of the Council presented the report. The Supplementary Planning Document (SPD) supported the effective implementation of the Greater Norwich Local Plan (GNLP) Policy 2: Sustainable Communities, providing guidance to applicants and planners on how to address the ten key social, economic and environmental issues outlined in Policy 2. Major developments were required to submit a Sustainability Statement to demonstrate how it would address the various aspects of Policy 2. The SPD outlined what these statements were required to cover to meet the policy requirements, points to useful sources of information and provided guidance on the submission of Health Impact Assessments, Delivery Plans and master-planning.

121.2 The SPD had been subject to a six-week public consultation. A report had been included at Appendix 2 of the report which detailed the responses received and how the SPD was amended to take into account the comments. The main focus of comments was on Table 2 (key requirements of policy 2) with several comments suggesting further documents and resources. Amendments to the policy included; highlighting the multifunctional benefits that arose from Green Infrastructure and adding additional information on Sustainable Drainage Systems; providing further detail regarding inclusivity; ensuring that development addresses potential pollution to groundwater and setting out that developers were recommended to investigate achieving higher standards set out in the Shared Standards in Water Efficiency for Local Plans document. Cabinet were asked to recommend that Full Council adopt the Supplementary Planning Document so that it became a material consideration in the determination of relevant planning applications.

121.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“As this supplementary planning document is intended to guide the creation of sustainable communities under Policy 2, can the Cabinet Member outline how the council will measure whether developments are actually delivering the social, environmental and infrastructure outcomes envisaged, beyond simply meeting minimum policy wording?”

121.4 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:

“The Policy 2 SPD will help applicants to ensure that they meet all policy requirements and ensure that decision makers approve planning applications that meet the standards. Conditions can be used on planning permissions to ensure that developments are built in accordance with the approved plans and documents.

SPDs can only supplement the policies in the Local Plan through explanation and interpretation. They cannot create new policy, so it is not possible for this SPD to require standards beyond that set out within policy 2. However, it should be noted that for certain issues Policy 2 sets higher standards than that required by the government.”

121.5 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

121.6 **RESOLVED** to recommend that Full Council adopt the GNLP Policy 2: Sustainable Communities Supplementary Planning Document.

122. Adoption of the Implementation of the Greater Norwich Green Infrastructure Strategy Supplementary Planning Document

122.1 The Leader of the Council presented the report. The Supplementary Planning Document (SPD) supported policies within the adopted Greater Norwich Local Plan (GNLP) and gave additional weight to the previously endorsed Greater Norwich Green Infrastructure Strategy (GNGIS) so that it could be used to support decision making. The GNGIS provided a framework for guiding and prioritising the most suitable types, locations and scale of Green Infrastructure required to support future

growth. The draft SPD underwent a six-week consultation. The full details of the consultation and amendments made to the SPD were reflected in the report. The main issues raised and the amendments made. This included further clarity on how the SPD would be used for new developments and determining applications as such a new section 2 had been created with an example of how the SPD could be used. A number of suggestions were made on different monitoring standards or methods, specific Green Infrastructure improvements and updates to the GNGIS; an update had not been made as the SPD was to support the existing policy and therefore new policy could not be made, the GNGIS was an existing endorsed document that could not be amended through the SPD process.

122.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“The Greater Norwich Green Infrastructure Strategy sets out an ambitious framework for protecting and enhancing green networks across the area. Can the Cabinet Member explain how delivery of the strategy will be monitored over time, particularly as governance arrangements change through Local Government Reorganisation?”

122.3 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:

“The Greater Norwich GI Strategy will be monitored in two ways:

1. Through work undertaken by the Green Infrastructure Project Team (GIPT). The GIPT are currently undertaking work to identify monitoring indicators and methods.
2. Through the GNLP annual monitoring report. The monitoring framework and indicators were agreed as part of the adoption of the GNLP and are reported on an annual basis.

Regardless of the boundaries ultimately decided through LGR, the Greater Norwich GI Strategy and the related SPD will remain as evidence and planning policy documents for the relevant geography of the Greater Norwich area.”

122.4 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

122.5 **RESOLVED** to recommend that Full Council adopt the Implementation of the Greater Norwich Green Infrastructure Supplementary Planning Document.

123. Draft Statement of Licensing Policy under the Licensing Act 2003

123.1 The Leader of the Council presented the report. The report detailed the revised Statement of Licensing Policy ahead of public consultation. The Licensing Act 2003 requires the Council to review and adopt a refreshed Licensing Policy every five years. The current policy expired in December 2026, therefore a refreshed policy was required to be updated by this date. The policy had been updated to reflect current legislation, national guidance and best practice. The policy had been subject to review by specialist legal advisors to ensure that the approach remained clear, defensible and aligned with the statutory licensing objectives. Subject to Cabinet approval the policy would be subject to a 12 week

consultation with statutory partners, licence holders, businesses and the wider public. Feedback would then be assessed and amendments brought before members before adoption by the Full Council.

123.2 The Leader noted that an additional recommendation had been made by the Licensing Committee which had been circulated as part of the tabled papers. The Cabinet indicated that it was willing to accept the following recommendation:

“Recommend that Cabinet considers exploring additional steps to address the safety of women and girls through the consultation process.”

123.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Night-time venues play an important role in the city's economy, but they also carry foreseeable safeguarding risks. How does the draft licensing policy ensure that venues take proactive responsibility for customer safety rather than relying primarily on reactive police enforcement after incidents occur?”

123.4 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:

“The draft Licensing Policy makes it clear that venues, not the police, must take proactive responsibility for safeguarding. Applicants are required to show, in their operating schedules, exactly how they will promote the licensing objectives, including ensuring public safety preventing crime, disorder and protecting children from harm.

The policy has been deliberately strengthened to require active safeguarding measures, reflecting council motions and national guidance. This includes working with venues to combat harassment, discrimination, spiking and violence against women and girls, and encouraging adoption of recognised best-practice schemes such as Ask for Angela, WAVE training, Night Safe Champion standards, and other national toolkits.

The policy makes clear that good management is essential, and applicants are expected to demonstrate how these approaches are built into daily management, staff training, and supervision.

Enforcement remains available, but the emphasis is on early intervention, robust operating schedules, and clear, enforceable licence conditions so problems are prevented long before police action becomes necessary.”

123.5 The Leader of the Council moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report and the additional recommendation from the Licensing Committee.

123.6 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Authorise the revised draft Statement of Licensing Policy to commence public consultation.

- 2) Consider exploring additional steps to address the safety of women and girls through the consultation process.

124. Biodiversity Duty Compliance Report 2023-2025

- 124.1 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment presented the report. The Environment Act 2021 had placed a duty on the Council to conserve and enhance biodiversity and create a policy on how the Council would deliver this. The reporting period ended on 31 December 2025 and the report before Cabinet met the Council's duty to publish its work. It also provided a good recap of the work that the Council had been able to successfully deliver. The Council's Biodiversity Strategy had been adopted in 2022. The actions that had been completed were detailed in Appendix 2 of the report. A biodiversity baseline study had been commissioned to support Biodiversity Net Gain (BNG) and to develop comprehensive nature recovery planning. To date two planning applications had been made that required BNG and more were expected. The Council had produced a BNG Guidance note to support local decision making. During the reporting period the Parks and Green Spaces Strategy had been adopted, parks and green spaces were managed to support biodiversity. The Local Nature Recovery Strategy had been developed by the County as it was the responsible authority. Norwich City Council, Broadland District Council and South Norfolk Council had adopted the Greater Norwich Green Infrastructure Strategy (GNGIS) which set out a shared approach to green infrastructure to strengthen the nature network. The adoption of the Supplementary Planning Document would strengthen its weight in decision-making.
- 124.2 Across the reporting period there had been a significant amount of work on nature recovery, including over 40,000 volunteer hours that had been completed across a range of sites and activities, including planting wildflower meadows, native hedgerows and community action. The Council had led a partnership bid to the National Lottery Heritage Fund alongside the Norfolk Wildlife Trust, Broadland District Council, South Norfolk Council and the County Council to bring residents closer to nature, particularly to communities most in need. There would be a review of the River Wensum Strategy to ensure that the action plan was updated to enhance the river.
- 124.3 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:
- "We welcome the considerable work already underway through Nature City Norwich, including the £750,000 partnership project, the focus on nature equity, the ambitious tree canopy target, and the innovative approaches to measuring biodiversity. The council is developing real expertise in nature recovery. However, given the scale of ecological decline nationally and the increasing expectation on local authorities to integrate nature recovery across all functions (as reflected in recent national policy shifts strengthening powers for councils to improve accessibility, environmental quality, and local nature networks) could the Cabinet member briefly set out how they will now move to operationally embed a genuinely cross-cutting approach to nature recovery across every department and ensure that all, from housing to street cleaning, contribute systematically to nature recovery, so that this work becomes a core and active organisational principle?"

124.4 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment gave the following response:

“The Biodiversity Duty Compliance Report evidences the extensive work undertaken by different teams and departments across the council. Having published our Biodiversity Strategy within months of the Environment Act 2021 coming into effect, the council positioned itself to quickly deliver the new biodiversity duty placed on local authorities.

A cross-council Biodiversity Working Group, with officer representatives from relevant teams in every directorate of the council, including representation from NCSL was established as part of our Biodiversity Strategy (2022-2032). This new approach to biodiversity governance has been fruitful as evidenced by the successful initiatives set out in the report.

These include the ‘Back Garden Nature’ pilot project; a collaboration with the council’s housing team to identify a win-win solution to overgrown gardens, with the council undertaking management of these sites as mini nature reserves with tenant consent.

Other examples include working with NCSL to create significant new high value habitat at Heartsease Recreation Ground.

Through the ‘Nature City Norwich’ project, we aim to introduce nature friendly land management practices across a significant portion of the 600 hectares of communal housing land owned by the council.

The council has developed a successful cross-cutting governance approach to embed biodiversity across its operations which it reports regularly to CEEEP and is evidenced in the Biodiversity Duty report. And we look forward to seeing the outputs of the Nature City Norwich project, as we develop this three-year citywide nature recovery project with our partners Norfolk Wildlife Trust, South Norfolk and Broadland and Norfolk County Council.

Our ambition for nature recovery is clear and so is our record of delivering it.”

124.5 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment moved, and the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

124.6 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Approve the Biodiversity Duty Compliance Report 2023-2025
- 2) Agree to publish the report in line with the statutory requirements of the Environment Act 2021.

125. Write-off of irrecoverable debt over £50,000

125.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects. The report requested the write-off of four debts where all reasonable steps had been taken to recover the debt, using the Council’s debt recovery process. The companies listed had formally

been dissolved and struck off and the Council was therefore unlikely to recover the debt. The amounts to be written-off were covered by the Council's bad debt provision and there was an option for the Council to recover the debt if there was an unexpected windfall.

125.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"This report proposes writing off significant business rates debts owed by large national retailers River Island and Poundland, where recovery action was halted following High Court approved restructuring plans. Can the Cabinet Member explain how the council seeks to safeguard public funds in situations where major companies restructure and local authorities are prevented from pursuing recovery; were they aware and sighted on how such large debts were able to be built up without action taken to reclaim them before debtors went bust?"

125.3 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

"The council's net collectable debit at the end of February 2026 for Business Rates is £75.24m.

These two write-offs totalling £320,587.04 represent 0.43% of the net collectable debit. The council has followed the legal process to recover these debts.

Both Council Tax and Business Rates are payable by instalments as the default payment method. As can be noted, the debts did not build up over a long period of time, with both companies paying their charge until their financial position rendered them unable to continue to do so. The council acted swiftly in sending the relevant reminder notices and summonses to both companies.

The council may be aware that a company may be facing financial difficulties, but if it continues to pay according to the payment plan the council cannot take any action until it falls into arrears.

The restructuring plans for both businesses were sanctioned by the High Court in August 2025, rendering the debts non-recoverable, however should a dividend be forthcoming relating to the company, which is unlikely and can take a long period of time to conclude, the council can write-on the debt to offset any dividend received.

The council has a bad debt provision for such eventualities, and the loss of income is shared by the council, Norfolk County Council and Central Government."

125.4 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

125.5 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Approve the write offs totalling £338,951.84 of non-recoverable Council Tax debt which is 100% covered within the Council Tax bad debt provision.

- 2) Approve the write offs totalling £320,587.04 of non-recoverable National Non-Domestic Rates (NNDR) debt which is 100% covered within the NNDR bad debt provision.

126. Procurement and contract award for bus shelter maintenance and advertising

126.1 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment presented the report. The report requested delegated authority to award the contract for the bus shelter maintenance and advertising. The Council had 150 bus shelters of which 127 were managed by the same supplier and had advertising panels that generated an income for the Council. The contract would ensure that it was clear and enforceable that the supplier would be responsible for maintenance and make safe any hazards. The report detailed that an advertisement would need to comply with legislation, Advertising Standards Agency guidelines and social advertising codes and the contract would specify that some content would not be suitable for specific shelters.

126.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Point 12 states that the new contract will require the supplier to remove advertising that the Council considers unsuitable on policy grounds or where permission is refused under the Control of Advertisement Regulations, with removal required within three working days; could the Cabinet member explain how this clause will be invoked in practice e.g. what council policy or statutory basis will underpin its use, whether it mirrors or differs from the equivalent provision in the existing long-standing contract, and if so how many times this power has been used during the past 30 years of the council’s relationship with the incumbent supplier?”

126.3 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment gave the following response:

“The successful supplier will be expected to comply with all current legislation, Advertising Standards Authority (ASA) rulings and associated Advertising Codes, which are written by the Committees of Advertising Practice (CAP).

The clause has been in the contract since the last renewal and whilst records wouldn’t exist going back through the full term of the contract, our current contract management staff are not aware of any receiving any complaints regarding bus shelter advertising content or having to formally request removal of unsuitable content in the last 5 years.”

126.4 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

126.5 **RESOLVED** to delegate authority to the Executive Director of Climate and Environment, in consultation with the Portfolio Holder for Climate and Environment, to award the contract to the selected supplier and enter into contract for these services following the procurement process via a compliant framework.

127. Delegated authority to award the main contract for City Hall accessibility works

127.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects presented the report. The report was to delegate authority to award the main contract for City Hall accessibility works, this would be essential works, including new lifts and automatic doors. Once planning consent had been granted the contractor would be able to commence works quickly.

127.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“We welcome the decision to fast-track the accessibility improvements to the ground floor of City Hall, including the new ramp, lift, automatic doors and accessible toilet facilities, and it is positive to see this work progressing ahead of the wider City Hall Reimagined project. However, as these enhancements apply only to part of the building, could the Cabinet Member set out her thoughts on how the remainder of City Hall will be made fully accessible in future, and outline her five top priorities for ensuring that accessibility is embedded across the whole building as subsequent phases of work are developed and delivered?”

127.3 The Cabinet Member for Planning and Regulatory Services gave the following response:

“Thank you for the question. This administration is absolutely committed to making City Hall a building that everyone can use, and that’s exactly why we took swift action to fast-track the ground-floor accessibility works. These improvements are the start, not the finish.

The rest of the building will be addressed through our wider City Hall Reimagined plans. In November we agreed to move those proposals to the next stage, including seeking planning and listed building consent, and my priorities for embedding accessibility across the whole building are clear:

1. A comprehensive whole-building accessibility plan guiding every phase.
2. Improved, fully inclusive circulation across all floors.
3. More and better accessible facilities reflecting all disabilities and protected characteristics.
4. Designing beyond minimum standards, using expert advice and best practice.
5. Putting lived experience first, through ongoing engagement with disabled residents and building users.

We are determined that the reimagined City Hall will set a new standard for accessibility while working sensitively and creatively within the responsibilities that come with a listed building.”

127.4 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

127.5 **RESOLVED** to delegate authority to the Executive Director of Major Projects, in consultation with the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects, to award the main contract for the accessibility works to City Hall at a value of approximately £500,000.

128. Procurement and contract award for Phase 1 repairs to St Andrews multi storey car park (MSCP)

128.1 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment presented the report. The report detailed the commencement of the procurement process for the Phase 1 repairs to St Andrews multi-storey car park (MSCP). The car park generated a significant amount of income for the Council. A survey had identified a significant number of issues that if left unresolved could affect the safety of the car park in the long term. Acting at this point of time would ensure that costs did not increase further which could lead to the closure of the car park. Secondary works would be required in five to ten years time which would be measures such as resurfacing. During the Phase 1 works the car park would remain operational and a floor-by-floor approach would be taken to the works.

128.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“St Andrews MSCP is only 20 years old yet has already required major structural and safety interventions in 2015-16 and again in 2022 and now faces further significant steelwork and drainage repairs that mirror the national pattern of premature deterioration in multi-storey car parks. What steps will the Cabinet Member take to ensure that this cycle of repeated failures is broken, and can she outline what long-term asset management plan or design-life assessment will be put in place to prevent us returning to similar repair costs again within the next decade?”

128.3 The Leader of the Council gave the following response:

“Like many of our assets we are responsible for, the council has an ongoing commitment to ensuring these assets are kept in good condition and we continue to invest in great facilities for the city. We will continue to assess each of our assets such as our car parks, historic buildings, and structures to ensure that an agreed asset management approach is adopted and resources allocated appropriately. Of course, this will always be a challenge with limited resources and a significant number of assets to manage.”

128.4 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment moved, and the Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

128.5 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Approve the commencement of a procurement exercise for the Phase 1 repairs at St Andrews Multi-Storey Car Park (MSCP)
- 2) Delegate authority to the Executive Director of Climate and Environment, in consultation with the Portfolio Holder for Climate and Environment, to award the contract to the successful supplier.

129. Procurement and contract award for on-site security services for multi storey car parks and the market site

129.1 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment presented the report. The report related to out of hours security services for the car parks and security for the market site to ensure that these could remain safe and open. The Council had three car parks staffed by Council employees and the security would be to cover outside core hours. The market also required security, and the current contract was due to expire in July 2026. The report suggested a single contract for the services for a three-year period with the option to extend. The supplier would be required to pay staff a real living wage.

129.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“The new single security services contract will play a key role in managing safety and ASB across car parks and the market, What steps will the Cabinet Member take to ensure the contract supports a joined-up public-realm management approach: including rapid reporting of environmental issues, sharing ASB data with the Safer Norwich Partnership Board and Safer Norwich Strategy, and working alongside neighbourhood, cleansing and enforcement teams so that problems are addressed holistically rather than in isolation?”

129.3 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment gave the following response:

“The previous contract has worked well, and lessons have been learnt from the management and delivery over time. Officers as part of the monitoring of any new contract, work with many agencies, including those stated in the question to ensure problems are dealt with as they arise as efficiently as possible and this means working in partnership and ensuring problems are dealt with holistically. Regular reports are required from the supplier as part of the contract management procedures and where appropriate, this information is utilised to ensure a joined up public realm management approach.”

129.4 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

129.5 **RESOLVED** to delegate authority to the Executive Director of Climate and Environment, in consultation with the Portfolio Holder for Climate and Environment, to award and enter into a contract with the selected supplier following a procurement process via a compliant framework.

130. Delegated authority to award the procurement and award of replacement horticultural machinery and specialist vehicles for Norwich City Services Limited (NCSL)

130.1 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment presented the report. The report was to agree the use of capital funds to purchase critical equipment to deliver services including the maintenance of parks and open spaces and cleaning of streets. The total cost is around £528,000 which had been

allocated in the Capital Programme. Options had been explored and the best option was the direct purchase of the equipment.

130.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“It is good to see this investment in a Cleaner, Greener Norwich and in the equipment that will strengthen the delivery of grounds maintenance, cleansing and graffiti removal across the city. Norwich City Services Ltd will now have enhanced capacity, particularly through the new van-mounted pressure washer and upgraded street-cleansing fleet. Can the Cabinet Member confirm whether and when this investment will also enable NCSL to take on external revenue-generating projects where possible and once its core work is done: for example, contracted graffiti cleansing, and thereby reinvest some of the outlay and potentially grow the business as part of a more sustainable public-realm management model?”

130.3 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment gave the following response:

“Thank you for the question. This investment supports Councils aim of delivering a Cleaner, Greener Norwich and has been deliberately targeted at improving productivity and efficiency across our graffiti-removal, cleansing services and grounds maintenance.

The new equipment especially the van-mounted pressure washer and upgraded cleansing fleet will help enable faster response times, more consistent results, and a higher standard of service across the city.

Our immediate priority with NCSL is to embed these improvements within core operations. Strengthening day to day delivery will help create the additional capacity needed to grow our services over time.

Once those gains are fully realised, both the Council and NCSL will be in a stronger position to consider selective commercial opportunities such as contracted graffiti-removal work where this supports our wider strategy. Any future income generation would need to reinforce, not detract from, our core delivery and could offer opportunities to reinvest back into frontline services.

In short, this investment secures the improved service residents expect today while building the possibility to explore potential revenue generating activity in the future.”

130.4 The Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment moved, and the Cabinet Member for Equalities and Social Justice seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

130.5 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Agree to utilise £0.527m of the £1.465m already allocated in the Council’s capital programme for the purchase of new equipment for the Company.
- 2) Grant delegated authority to the Executive Director of Climate and Environment, in consultation with the Portfolio Holder for Climate and

Environment, for the procurement and award of contracts to purchase new equipment for the Company through a compliant framework.

131. Award of Housing Revenue Account (HRA) stock condition survey contract

131.1 The Cabinet Member for Housing presented the report. The stock condition survey was a crucial evidence base used to plan capital works and was a core requirement of the Regulator for Social Housing that the Council understood its stock. The Council was committed to being evidence-led to ensure that the Council was ensuring safe and secure homes. The Council needed to ensure that it spent Housing Revenue Account (HRA) capital in a responsible way. By having the evidence base it ensured that the Council was able to better plan long term capital programmes to reduce the amount of responsive repairs required and to improve energy efficiency ratings and minimising fuel costs. The stock condition survey would also strengthen compliance and ensuring that the Council had accurate information on its stock. A cyclical programme was required to be completed over the following three years.

131.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

“Norwich’s Housing Revenue Account stock is one of the city’s greatest assets and, given its scale, age profile and concentration, is unusually significant compared with many similar councils. Now we are nearing completion of the much needed initial stock-condition survey (required to meet the Regulator of Social Housing’s consumer standards and to provide accurate, property-level data), can the Cabinet Member set out how unusual Norwich’s HRA is when benchmarked against comparable authorities, and explain how this new contract will fit in to help ensure we fully understand and future-proof this unique asset. In particular, since retrofit for renewable energy is the challenge of our age, how will the survey methodology and data collection support long-term planning for decarbonisation, retrofit and low-carbon heating so that Norwich’s homes can meet both the Decent Homes 2 requirements and our wider climate objectives?”

131.3 The Cabinet Member for Housing gave the following response:

“You’re absolutely right that Norwich’s HRA stock is unusual. We have a large, diverse housing portfolio that many similar councils no longer have, which makes it both a major asset and a major responsibility. That’s why completing this full stock condition survey is so important.

The current stock condition survey meets the Regulator of Social Housing’s strengthened consumer standards, and gives us accurate, consistent data on each home. We have in place a single, modern, digital dataset for the entire HRA, and it will fundamentally improve our ability to plan investment, target resources and ensure homes meet both current and emerging standards.

Crucially, the survey has been designed with the future in mind. It collects the detailed information we need on insulation, heating systems, ventilation and building fabric to understand how each home can be improved. That means it will

directly support planning for Decent Homes 2, but also for long term decarbonisation, retrofit and low carbon heating solutions.

In simple terms, this dataset will help us map out the best and most cost-effective routes to making our homes warmer, more energy efficient and climate ready. It also puts Norwich in a much stronger position to secure future government funding for retrofit.

So, this contract isn't just about meeting today's standards, it's about future proofing one of Norwich's most important public assets for the next generation."

131.4 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved and the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

131.5 **RESOLVED** to delegate authority to Executive Director of Communities and Housing, in consultation with the Cabinet Member for Housing, to award and enter into a contract with the selected supplier following a procurement process via a compliant framework.

Item	Action	Works Programme	Value
1	Delegated authority	Contract over three years to deliver stock condition surveys and associated services to the HRA Housing stock	£550,000

132. Managing Assets (Non-Housing)

132.1 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects presented the report. The report detailed an update on the work to deliver the strategic asset management framework. To ensure that the disposal programme could be delivered. The Council was committed to ensuring it used public assets in the most appropriate and ensure that the Council remained financial resilient to protect services. The remaining assets were increasingly complex and the Council had considered whether these were tenanted and taken a measured approach to reduce liabilities while improving performance.

132.2 Councillor Galvin asked the following question:

"The Council has now disposed of £53.6m of assets against a target of £31.2m, and £4.7m this year against a target of £3.9m, with a further £2.3m under offer. As the programme now moves into the more complex part of the 'tail' of the less financially profitable stock we own, how are we ensuring: that social value, as well as economic return, is fully factored into disposal decisions, what adjustments have been made in light of this, and how is the Cabinet Member keeping sight of the community impacts as these decisions become more sensitive?"

132.3 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects gave the following response:

“Thank you for acknowledging our outstanding success in delivering the Council’s asset disposal programme. Exceeding these targets is a significant achievement and reflects the disciplined, strategic approach we’ve taken to managing the city’s assets responsibly.

As set out clearly in the Cabinet report, we are now entering the more complex phase of the programme, and we are navigating it with care and political purpose. Our approach strikes the right balance between delivering the Asset Strategy and protecting the social value that so many of our tenants contribute to communities across Norwich. The papers before you today show exactly how seriously we take that responsibility.

We also have a strong record of using our assets to drive community benefit. The Norwich Unity Hub at Carrow House is a prime example of how a Labour-led Council can repurpose its estate to create meaningful social value rather than simply opting for the quickest commercial return.

I maintain close oversight of all sensitive disposals, ensuring decisions remain transparent, proportionate and firmly aligned with our wider community priorities”

132.4 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

132.5 **RESOLVED** to:

- 1) Note progress made in implementing the Strategic Asset Management Framework
- 2) Delegate the disposal of assets listed within the exempt appendix to the Executive Director of Major Projects, in consultation with the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects.
- 3) Agree to the additional resource outlined in the report to be funded from capital receipts via disposal of assets.

133. Exclusion of the Public

133.1 **RESOLVED** to exclude the press and public from the meeting during the consideration of the below items of the exempt report on the grounds that they contained exempt information as defined in the relevant paragraphs within Part 1 of Schedule 12A, as amended, of the Local Government Act 1972.

134. East Norwich Regeneration (Para 3)

134.1 (An exempt minute exists for this item).

134.2 The Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects moved, and the Cabinet Member for Housing seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

134.3 **RESOLVED** that the following recommendations were accepted as detailed in the report.

134.4 (An exempt minute exists for this item).

135. Disposal of Assets (Housing) (Para 3)

135.1 (An exempt minute exists for this item).

135.2 The Cabinet Member for Housing moved, and the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment seconded the recommendations for the reasons set out in the report.

135.3 **RESOLVED** that the following recommendations were accepted as detailed in the report.

135.4 (An exempt minute exists for this item).

CHAIR



Cabinet

11 March 2026

Questions to cabinet members

Question 1

Councillor Champion to ask the cabinet member for housing the following question:

“A number of important nesting sites for highly endangered swifts, on homes close to Sweetbriar Marsh in Wensum ward were recently blocked off by council. I am glad that after we raised the matter alongside concerned residents, the council acted and some of the blockages have been removed, and swift boxes put up. I am however concerned that this risk to biodiversity was not picked up earlier in the council's contracting system. How many other council properties are having this new, unnecessary and very damaging anti bird comb fitted?”

Councillor Jones, the cabinet member for housing's response:

“Thank you, Councillor Champion, for your question and for the constructive engagement from residents and the Norwich Swift Network on this issue.

Following concerns raised about blocked swift nesting sites near Sweetbriar Marsh, officers acted quickly to remove the obstruction where appropriate and install replacement swift boxes. I share your view that the risk to biodiversity should be picked up earlier in our contracting processes, and we have already begun strengthening these arrangements.

To directly answer your question, we are currently auditing council homes where antibird comb has recently been installed to identify any other locations where it may be inappropriate or unnecessary. Early indications suggest that use of this material has been limited, but the audit will ensure we have a clear, accurate picture and can take corrective action where required.

More broadly, we see this as an opportunity to embed biodiversity improvements into our new capital works programme. We are working with our contractors, who have already expressed interest in supporting this—to develop social value initiatives such as installing swift boxes during roof works, and exploring wider ecological enhancements including bat boxes, insect habitats, water butts, and options for green or brown roofs where suitable.

It is important that this work is done correctly. Swift habitat, in particular, depends on highly specific locations, and we will be using tools such as Swift Mapper and working with experienced partners to guide placement. Contractor training will also

be strengthened, for example to ensure scaffolding does not inadvertently make existing nesting boxes unusable.

Resident involvement will be an important part of this work, particularly in monitoring nesting activity and supporting wider environmental improvements around their homes.

Our next steps are to:

1. Define a set of biodiversity and ecological initiatives that we expect contractors to deliver as part of their social value commitments;
2. Confirm the financial value allocated to social value within the new contracts and agree the proportion to dedicate to environmental improvements; and
3. Hold joint sessions with contractors to agree immediate and longer term plans.”

Supplementary question

By way of a supplementary question Councillor Champion asked whether the Cabinet Member would consider conducting an audit of Council homes on the use of bird come and bringing an update on the matter to the Climate and Environment Emergency Executive Panel. In response the Cabinet Member for Housing confirmed that the Cabinet was committed to addressing this, following the concerns raised officers acted quickly to address this. Work was underway to understand the Council's stock and a clear and accurate picture was required. Two new capital works contractors had recently started and the Council was working with the contractors to add social value.

Question 2

Councillor Stutely to ask the cabinet member for finance and major projects the following question:

“Given that demolition has commenced at Anglia Square and Schedule 7 of the Section 106 Agreement requires the Anglia Square Management Plan to be approved and updated every six months from first implementation, with annual submissions to the Council, can the Cabinet member responsible confirm that the Plan has been approved and updated in accordance with those requirements and outline how its construction-phase marketing, activation and trader liaison measures are being delivered during the current demolition phase?”

Councillor Harper, the cabinet member for finance and major projects' response:

“Thank you

I can confirm that the Anglia Square Management Plan was submitted to planning in April 2025 and was approved on 2 May 2025.

The purpose of the Anglia Square Management Plan was to seek to mitigate the impact of the Development on the businesses and tenants on the site during the construction of the Development. This was at a time when demolition and construction activity was to take place on site at the same time with some businesses continuing to trade on site during these activities.

Upon acquiring the site, it was clear to the Council that this was not feasible due to the condition of the buildings, and an alternative strategy was implemented to gain vacant possession of the site to enable full demolition to take place.

Measures implemented to support those existing businesses included payment to the Local Enterprise Centre, MENTA, to provide 12 months of business support, the creation of St Saviours Yard as a significantly enhanced meanwhile use opportunity over what was anticipated in the S106 agreement, support to secure alternative suitable accommodation and financial compensation to tenants for a period of time and further financial payments to cover removal and storage costs.

The S106 also required engagement with the Magdalen Street and Anglia Square Traders Association. This group no longer exists, but early discussions were held with the revised Magdalen Street Traders Association on the proposals and further engagement will take place as plans develop for the construction phase of the development.”

Supplementary question

As a supplementary question Councillor Stutely asked whether the management plan had been updated to reflect the current demolition phase. In response the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects confirmed that the document was updated as required. The Council was not able to mitigate all disruptions.

Question 3

Councillor Knight to ask the deputy leader and cabinet member for climate and environment the following question:

“With the cabinet making the decision to delegate awarding the contract for bus shelters, will the cabinet put conditions on the awarding of this contract to safeguard residents against unethical advertising?”

Councillor Hampton, the deputy leader and cabinet member for climate and environment's response:

“The Advertising Standards Authority (ASA) makes sure adverts across UK stick to the advertising rules known as the Advertising Codes.

Some adverts are already banned by law—such as those for alcohol-masking products, betting systems, tobacco, e-cigarettes, offensive weapons, and obscene material. These are not allowed on bus shelters now or under any future contract.

Norwich has also strengthened restrictions on HFSS (High Fat, Salt, and Sugar) near schools and in addition the contract also allows the Council to request the removal of unsuitable adverts from specific shelters within three working days.”

Supplementary question

In response to Councillor Knight’s supplementary question the Deputy Leader and Cabinet Member for Climate and Environment confirmed that the Council was only able to consider the content of adverts where it commissioned or controlled them. An example of this was Citizen magazine or the bus shelters. When the Ethical Advertising motion had been agreed the Council had considered whether advertising could be a potential income stream, it had not been possible due to the significant amount of resource required to create and monitor a policy.

Please note that the following questions are second questions and will only be taken if the total time for questions has not exceeded 30 minutes.

Question 4

Councillor Stutely to ask the leader of the council the following question:

“Can the Cabinet Member for outline how the draft licensing policy recognises and addresses the foreseeable risks of sexual harassment and spiking in licensed premises under the crime and disorder and public safety objectives, and whether further strengthening in this area would be welcomed through consultation?”

Councillor Stonard, the leader's response:

“The draft licensing policy takes a much stronger stance on the risks of sexual harassment and spiking in our night-time economy. This was an area of deliberate focus when reviewing and revising the policy, and Premises Licence Holders and applicants are encouraged to incorporate safeguards against such forms of behaviour.

The policy sets clear expectations on new applicants and recommends the adoption of recognised safeguarding measures—such as WAVE training, Ask for Angela, and wider night-time safety initiatives—as part of the crime and disorder objective. These are explicitly referenced in the draft policy as examples of best practice for preventing harassment, spiking, and related harms.

These safety measures can be recommended for new licenses where appropriate, on a case-by-case basis, but for existing premises the legislation only allows us to promote best practice rather than impose new conditions unilaterally. The revised policy therefore provides strong guidance and clear expectations while staying within the legal framework.

This remains a draft for consultation, and we welcome views from all stakeholders on adequacy and necessity of all the suggested measures during the consultation period”

Supplementary Question

By way of a supplementary question Councillor Stutely asked whether the Cabinet would consider strengthening the policy to include measures that respond to spiking. In response the Leader said that this would need to be considered as part of the consultation.

Question 5

Councillor Stutely to ask the cabinet member for finance and major projects the following question:

“At the January meeting the Cabinet Member advised Council that the refurbished toilets at St Saviours Yard remain available for public use and that members of the public can obtain the entry code from the site manager or one of the traders.

Can the Cabinet Member clarify what formal arrangements are in place to ensure the public can reliably obtain access to the facilities during opening hours?”

Councillor Harper, the cabinet member for finance and major projects' response:

“Thank you

It should be noted that the toilet block on St Saviours Yard had been shut to the public for over 15 years and was not available at all until the creation of the container development.

We have confirmed with the leaseholder of St Saviours Yard, Meanwhile Creative, that the refurbished toilet block on site has coded locks to prevent anti-social behaviour such as drug use, which has been an on-going issue with some members of the public that have gained access to the toilets.

Meanwhile Creative have confirmed that the toilet block is available to traders and to their customers, upon request for the code, and this will be monitored and reviewed if further anti-social behaviour occurs.

This enables some provision of toilets in the area whilst maintaining a safe environment for those that need to use the facilities.

There is also a requirement for new public toilets and a changing places facility to be provided on the new Anglia Square development which will be delivered in due course”

Supplementary Question

As a supplementary question Councillor Stutely asked whether the toilets would be available to members of the public that were not customers. In response the Cabinet Member for Finance and Major Projects said the Council was aware of the issues with the signage but the issue had been rectified, it was clarified on the signage that anyone could ask for the code to the toilets.